Discussions on inclusive, participative and open museums

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Abstract: This article discusses how museum professionals are shifting their professional practices of public engagement from social inclusion, accessibility and participation towards openness. Against this background we situate and present a part of our on-going research in the AvoinGLAM initiative. More specifically we discuss a series of workshops conducted by the authors. The key objective of these workshops was to collectively develop strategies on how to open content[1] and data held by Finnish cultural institutions, and how to open up professional processes for the general public. In the workshop, the participants from cultural heritage and memory institutions performed predefined group work. For example, they mapped possibilities and challenges for engaging various audiences and participatory approaches. The main questions that we address in this article are: How to motivate museums towards openness? What is the contribution that this discussion on openness can bring to museums?

Keywords: participation, open culture, social inclusion, design, museums

Introduction

Audience inclusion in cultural heritage institutions has been an important focus for a long time (Research Center for Museums and Galleries, 2000). Many institutions have attempted to make their content available to people with different needs (Sandell 2007) and from different cultural backgrounds (Karp & Lavine 1991). There are a number of mobile libraries and museums that visit hospitals, senior's homes and prisons.[2] Many networks, conferences and publications have enriched discussions on inclusion and accessibility.[3] Museum professionals know a lot about physical accessibility issues related to their collections and exhibitions, and this knowledge has been developed into specific guidelines and policies adopted by many museums.[4] As collections are being increasingly digitized, and museums are moving their offerings and services to technology platforms on the Internet, there is a growing need to bring issues on digital accessibility to the museum agenda (Lisney et al. 2013).

Emphasis on participatory practices dominated discussions about museums in the last decade.[5] This was supported and sustained by the introduction of new technologies in the cultural heritage sector and efforts towards digitalization. New digital tools provided by the museums gave communities of visitors a possibility to e.g. tag, bookmark and comment on the materials that are exhibited in both the physical space in the museum and online. There are also other means and strategies used to engage the public and stimulate participation in the GLAM (galleries, libraries, archives and museums) sector. In libraries, archives and museums there are interesting efforts being made making it easier to classify and recommend books.[6] Visitors are encouraged to take part in these activities that previously were done by organization's own staff members. Through these participatory practices visitors are in contact with the collection before, during and after the visit. Their involvement with the organization is taken into consideration in order to enrich the collection, and as a source of inspiration for future initiatives. The focus in these cases is mostly on how people can participate in the current practices of the institutions and share their knowledge or experiences on the cultural heritage content. However, by concentrating on these practices, we easily overlook the fact that this content is already selected, curated and contextualized by professionals in the cultural sector. The entire collection is rarely, if ever open to participatory endeavors. In addition, each project and institution in which these practices have been encouraged has set strict limitations on what can be done with the curated material. Creative interpretations and appropriations performed by the museum audience are framed into participatory practices addressed to general public.

Participatory approaches have opened alternative possibilities for visitors and special groups to interact with museum collections. In this way these approaches have paved the way for open

[1] Open Knowledge Foundation's definition of open content is: "a piece of data or content is open if *anyone* is *free to use, reuse, and redistribute* it" [emphasis Salgado & Marttila]. For a full description of the definition see http://opendefinition.org/okd/.
[2] See e.g. Arts & Audiences, 2012.
[3] See e.g. Museums and Social Issues. and the International Journal of the Inclusive Museum.
[4] See e.g. Smithsonian museum's accessibility program http://www.si.edu/accessibility.
[5] See for e.g. Simon, 2009.
[6] See e.g. Yin-Ling & Arroyo, 2012 or Tran, 2009.

strategies in which the audience is invited to interact with the museum collection using alternative means. Museums using open strategies invite professionals to be part in the decision making process that influence the core museum actions. These professionals can design products and services based on the collection that facilitate and invite new audiences. This includes the creation of interpretation materials such as mobile applications that may allow new audiences to engage with museum collections. The collection is completely open for interpretations, not only by the museum personnel but also by external collaborators in their role of professionals.

This article discusses how to embrace approaches on social inclusion, accessibility, participation and openness in the museum in order to better understand benefits of opening museum collections, collaborative processes and professional museum practices. We build both on theory and practice-based research. The empirical material discussed is obtained from a series of workshops organized by the authors in the context of the AvoinGLAM initiative. The key objective of these collaborative workshops was to collectively develop strategies to open content and data held by Finnish cultural institutes, and discuss how to open up professional processes and practices for the general public.

Research methods

AvoinGLAM ("Avoin" means "open" in Finnish and "GLAM" stands for Galleries, Libraries, Archives and Museums) is a network of people and organizations with the aim of opening up content and data held by the Finnish memory institutions. The AvoinGLAM initiative aims to establish more open and transparent organizational culture, facilitate and support for artists, designers and practitioners to use and re-use open cultural content and data. This initiative builds upon the international OpenGLAM[7] initiative set up by Open Knowledge Foundation, and shares their fundamental mission and approach on building an open culture.

The AvoinGLAM initiative was originally launched in connection with the Open Knowledge Festival 2012. It was later restructured as a working group under Open Knowledge Finland association (Marttila, forthcoming). Under the initiative, various activities have been organized including talks, seminars and workshops in Finland. This paper reviews four collaborative workshops conducted and facilitated by the authors in different cities in Finland: Helsinki, Forssa, Tampere and Pori. The overall aim of these workshops was to promote practices and tools related to openness in cultural heritage and memory institutions. We seeked to understand and collaboratively map the status quo in Finnish cultural institutions, and bring together actors to share experiences and good practices, thus providing a platform to learn from each other and build a vital network.

In the workshops, participants from cultural heritage and memory institutions performed predefined group work, including collaboratively mapped possibilities and challenges of sharing authorship, engaging the public, and releasing content with more open terms of use. The empirical material obtained from the four workshops consists of: predefined and prepared assignments that were performed and discussed by the participants; records of discussions and presentations of assignments; and notes by the workshop facilitators. Two of the workshops, in Helsinki and Forssa, were scheduled for a whole day, giving more emphasis on an introductory lecture and a general discussion. Two other workshops, in Tampere and Pori, were shorter and lasted approximately half a day. In the latter workshops only some of the assignments were carried out. In total there were about 60 participants in the workshops, the majority coming from the GLAM sector.

All of the workshops followed the same structure: a general lecture on openness in terms of meaning and levels, along with example of projects, group work in small groups based on predefined assignments, group presentations and final discussion. The themes of the assignments were: 1) mapping the current situation in cultural organizations; 2) the roles of cultural organizations in society; 3) how to build an accessible GLAM organization? 4) participatory approaches and public engagement methods in GLAM organization – current practices and envisioning the future; and 5) the principles of openness in GLAM organizations. Small groups of participants performed the assignments and discussed the issues presented above. After three to five rounds of group work, participants presented their outcomes, and summarized the key points of their discussions. Every workshop ended with a general discussion based on the group's presentations, including questions by the participants.

[7] OpenGLAM is an initiative launched in December 2011 by Open Knowledge Foundation. For more information see http://openglam.org.

The empirical data was analyzed without predefined hypotheses or preconceived theories. The data from each workshop was categorized based on assignments; emphasis was given to themes and topics that occurred in many responses. After reviewing the outcomes of the workshop assignments, three key topics and developments ensued that are relevant to the museum domain: social inclusion and accessibility, participatory approaches and open practices.

In the following part of this paper these themes are elaborated through the empirical findings, however at the same time we aim to situate and contextualize the themes in the current discussion in museum studies.

Overview of the approaches and analysis

1. Social inclusion and accessibility

There are many strategies to build an inclusive and accessible museum (Sandell 2002 & 2007). Most of them put an emphasis on who is invited to engage with the exhibitions both online and on site. In Finland, efforts are directed towards inviting people with special needs, people of different ages and people from different social backgrounds. In addition, a manual on how to build accessible exhibitions was published in Finland (Teräsvirta 2007). Various museums have produced and published guidelines and policies on their accessibility program.[8]

In context of our workshops, accessibility in relation to museum collections was discussed especially in the assignment on "how to build an accessible GLAM organization?" In this task participants were asked to identify the communities with whom their organization is involved and interacting with, and name the activities that made these communities engage with the cultural organizations. In the assignment we asked the participants to place the communities in a big outer circle, and name and place the participatory activities in smaller consecutive circles. Communities or actors identified in this task by the participants encompassed a wide range of user groups, including refugees, immigrants, social discriminated people, students at different levels of education, artists, researchers, volunteers, virtual visitors, public sector, non-users, authorities and companies. The actions described different ways to bring collections and museum core activities near the museum community using different strategies. For example, in the Modern Art Museum in Pori they have sessions for babies to paint. These events are called 'Color Baths' and babies use eatable materials for painting. In this case, the museum is making a special invitation to babies to have contact with the artistic practice of painting.

Mapping these activities and/or projects in the workshops creates the possibility for participants to trace the link between accessible endeavors in which they have been involved, and the open approach. In addition, reflecting on these matters made the participants face their own contradictions and preconceptions related to openness.

In the workshop in Tampere, the participants acknowledged a need to have new professionals in museums with expertize on digitalization, intellectual property issues and technology. This expertise might increase the knowledge of the community on (currently) foreign issues (e.g. open data and copyright issues).

'Open' is sometimes perceived in relation to technical and copyrights challenges, not in terms of the possibility for audience engagement and interaction with cultural heritage content. The task of mapping organizations' actions in relation to actors for a accessible GLAM made participants consider open approaches as a possibility to engage with new audiences, such as volunteers and developers. In addition, participants in the assignment developed strategies on how to be more accessible. These included communication and collaboration activities, providing access to collections and catalogues, the use of social media and new tools for new audiences. Creating access was understood as being not only about inviting groups with special needs but also about widening the community that could be interested in collections, and motivating these newcomers through open practices.

2. Participatory approaches

In recent years there have been many initiatives in which museums facilitate the participation of the audience: as special groups invited to bring their own personal objects to the museum;[9] to curate

[8] See e.g. Smithonian Accessibility Program, 2013.
[9] See e.g. Helinä Rautavaara Museum 2008 & Simon 2007.

exhibitions from the museum collection;[10] to be part of the design process from the beginning;[11] or to comment on the exhibited material.[12] With the widespread use of participatory practices and the consequence validation of audience participation, visitors' contributions started to be part of the museum concept. Social media and digital tools have exaggerated this effect because they have made it possible for museums to direct their call for contributions to different groups of people using different media formats and services. Making the audience's comments and materials sharable is easier once it can be part of the museum's online presence. Co-creation of heritage happens mainly in online platforms and in workshops, however, in the exhibition spaces this co-creation is rarely exhibited.

In the workshops, certain cases came up as models of co-creation of cultural heritage material. For example a group of volunteers interested in history and wanting to contribute to museum work are taking part in the core activities in the Worker's Museum in Tampere. This group of people work on activities related to their own interests and they take part in activities related to the collection, including: listing, photographing, documenting, scripting the exhibition, building and design, plan and production of events (Työväenmuseo 2013). *Solmu* created by Mediamuseo Rupriikki provides another example. Here they ask citizens to comment and/or add material to their existing database of videos, photographs and texts (Museosolmu, year unknown). Participants' own cases demonstrated that participatory approaches are desired, and motivated through creating practices to collaborate with different communities that are interested in the collection. The concerns in relation to these participatory approaches relate mostly to the issue of the sustainability of projects. Projects are generally limited in time and once the funding is over, it is hard to continue.

Open strategies for participation include letting the museum community take part in the core activities of the museum, including work on the collection, organizing events, choosing the exhibition topic, design, selection of material to be included and making the interpretation and communication materials for the exhibition. This can only be done with special invitation to external collaborators such as associations and communities with special interests related to the museum collection. Creating trust within the museum community is fundamental to a more fruitful collaboration where there are less concerns on the possible outcomes. This only happens with time and commitment to reinforcing open practices.

3. Open practices

Holistic participation in exhibition formation or enrichment of the collection is unfortunately far from the norm. The term 'museum community' is generally understood as the community to which the museum belongs. Museum studies typically show a clear division between museum personnel and audiences (e.g. Golding & Modest 2013). In this paper, when we refer to 'museum community' we refer to 'museum personnel and audience'. Through our work in the context of museums we have understood the importance of the inclusion of other members of the museum community such as museum personnel, artists and/or designers that have pieces in the exhibitions, museum friends, associations, online visitors and others interested in the museum collection such as hobbyists. All these groups can be invited to take part in defining museum actions and strategies.

When museums release open content, they do not imply special invitations to interact with their collection. People can engage by creating services, products or interpretations based on the collection without asking permission. If museums facilitate the engagement of people with their content, they could learn about developers, designers and newcomers interested in museums' collection. Understanding that each partnership demands other types of calls and ways to contribute is part of the work for supporting open practices that could lead to new forms of collaboration. Museums could be part of facilitating open practices by creating open calls to work with their collection. These calls have different formats such as: memory sessions, wiki marathons, hackathons[13] and wiki workshops (edit-a-thons).

[10] See e.g. Bath & North East Somerset 2003.
[11] See e.g. Taxen 2004.
[12] See e.g. Mc. Lean & Pollock 2007; Salgado 2009a.
[13] A "hackathon" (also known as a "hack day", "hackfest" or "codefest") is an event in which computer programmers, designers, managers and the public collaborate intensively on creating a software project. Occasionally, there is a hardware component as well. Hackathons typically last between a day and a week in length. Some hackathons are intended simply for educational or social purposes, although in many cases the goal is to create usable software. Hackathons tend to have a specific focus. Some hakathons were hosted in museums and libraries and relate to creating material on their content (source: Wikipedia).

Participants referred to networks and collaborative projects of different scales - such as Europeana,[14] FINNA,[15] Museoraitti,[16] Virtuaalipolku,[17] Kuulto,[18] and Solmu[19] - as fundamental for reaching external collaborators and motivating them to share the collection and release some of the content through open licenses. In this context museum professionals are worried, and have some resistance. One participant in the workshops put it this way: "we are reluctant to open the collection to the public because we do not have all the information related to the collection. The information has some gaps. We do not want to share these inaccuracies".[20] For conservation experts, thinking how to share their content is a new practice: "in a sense we think that our responsibility is to conserve, so if we offer the whole collection to the public, what remains for us? This is a bit of an exaggerated way of saying this, but it is like this".

Issues related to open practices, content and data are a challenge: "we are afraid that we are not using the copyright laws correctly, so we prefer not to take risks. The fear takes over from the possible benefits that sharing the collection might have". This ongoing conversation on openness that took place in the workshops reassures an increasing acknowledgement on the challenges related to the process of releasing content with more open terms and conditions.

In the future, there could be ways to track all the possible uses of this content. Museums' involvement in the creation of open practices is vital to co-design these opportunities. In relation to this, a participant in one of our workshop stated: "if we open the collection, we want to be sure that some of the created material related to our collection comes back to us, that we can enrich the collection whilst opening". Museums can open their content, but the collection might not benefit in terms of its enrichment, but in respect to its visibility. Collections will be seen, used, interpreted and recreated in unexpected ways. This is an open approach that involves certain risks and a trust towards the future uses that people could invent for the collection.

Findings from the workshops

In the previous sections of this paper we reviewed our empirical material, and identified and discussed themes relevant to the contemporary museum studies discourse on museum practices. From the research material coming from the workshops, we understood that discourses about an inclusive, participative and open museum are part of the everyday life of cultural organizations. In this section we build a path from accessible, to open, in order to weave a better understanding on present challenges in the sector.

An inclusive museum can be thought as a museum that opens to collaborations and partnerships. Inspired by these different audiences, museum professionals enhance their exhibitions and also their way of engaging with different communities. By opening content, new audiences will connect with it. This can be a source for enriching practices and collection, and reinforce the commitment to the audience.

A participative museum provides the audience with new ways of engaging with their collections by taking part in selecting, commenting, voting, and bookmarking materials from the exhibitions. Through this committed engagement with the different groups of people interested in their collections, museums are able to develop a sense of trust that allows them to enrich their collections.

An open museum is an idea that departs from sharing content and data in cultural organizations and could develop alternative practices that do not require organization consent. Products, services and new interpretations of the collection will come once alternative ways of using open content are created.

The open museum is not a recent phenomenon.[21] However, participants in the workshops realized that this is the right moment of this discussion in Finland because they appreciate the benefits of the open approaches and they are increasingly taking part in projects, which involve sharing the collection using open licenses.

[14] http://www.europeana.eu/
[15] https://www.finna.fi/?lng=en-gb
[16] http://www.museoraitti.fi/
[17] http://www.virtuaalipolku.fi/index.php?option=com_content&view=article&id=219
[18] https://www.jyu.fi/ytk/laitokset/yfi/oppiaineet/kup/tutkimus/tutkprojhank/kuulto
[19] http://www.museosolmu.fi/
[20] Free translations made by the authors.
[21] See e.g. Kelly, et al. 2008 and Salgado 2009b.

The workshops were instances of dialogue between participants, and provided a rich body of material for further analysis. The workshops, like pulleys, facilitated collaboration between participants and provided a possibility to arrive at a common understanding and interpretation in relation to openness. They also facilitated network building.

It is no longer the cultural heritage institution that coordinates the participatory practices, but immaterial property is made available publicly. In these conditions some ethical concerns appear: Who is responsible for the use of this content? How can cultural institutions ensure that the inclusion and participation related to their content happens under their own rules and conditions? What if what is created goes against the vision and mission of the institution? What are the ethical and moral considerations of being open?

Similar questions were posed once we gave the audience the opportunity to participate and provide content material to the exhibitions. The result in these cases was surprisingly positive. People were eager to enrich the material in many ways. Vandalism or negative interventions are seldom part of these endeavors.[22] Therefore, we believe that in the case of opening the content and data, we will see similarly positive results. People eager to volunteer and to create materials on the basis of a cultural organization's collection, will respect this content because the aim is to contribute to reinforce open approaches.

Many participatory initiatives happen as an initiative of educators in the museum context. Educators have been historically the ones nurturing the dialogue with the audiences, by providing different approaches through which visitors are involved with materials in exhibitions. In relation to our study, archivists and researchers could have a meaningful role in supporting the process towards open approaches.

Nurturing trust with the museum community, with external collaborators that could be interested in using the museum collection in unexpected ways is a fundamental part of museum actions towards openness. Museums can build this trust by encouraging external collaborators to engage with their collections and create from them. Wide spread participatory approaches using open strategies for collaboration is the basis of nurturing trust with the museum community and moving towards openness.

Conclusions and implications for future study

This paper offers a preliminary analysis of four workshops that took place in Finland during 2012/13. There is a need to continue the dialogue related to these issues and future analysis of the material gathered will be undertaken. Workshops in the future could to be complemented with clinics in which consultation on how to move projects one step towards openness is given. The workshops we conducted provided a possibility to map projects, activities and actors. They were successful in involving new players in the museum, providing a space to co-create a common vocabulary in Finnish, and providing arguments to negotiate with resistant players within the organizations.

In this paper we only provide a narrow analysis that traces links within already existing discussions in the museum: social inclusion and accessibility, participation and openness. Drawing on the well-established discourses on social inclusion, accessibility and participation it will be possible to build the open museum.

Openness in cultural memory institutions could make a significant contribution in the sector because it entails new invitations to different actors within the museum community. Previously, when accessibility and participation were the main paradigms in cultural organizations, educators and curators had a key role in designing and implementing access and participation. In this shift towards openness conservators, experts in digitalization and researchers are also gate openers within the museum. In addition, it encourages the involvement of external collaborators in their role as professionals. In the case of open practices, the audience is not only taking part in commenting, tagging and bookmarking, but also in the production and design of visualizations, products and services based on the museum collection. This time the audience takes part in their role as experts that can design, publish and make invitations facilitating other groups to engage with the collection. This changes the perspective and raises new challenges for collaborations with an unknown community of people that is interesting in designing products and services based on museum collections. In order to see the potential of this

[22] See e.g. Salgado, 2009a

community, museums need to create new spaces, networks and ways of working together, such as *hackathons* in which designers, museum professionals, practitioners and the community collide.

Museums could be motivated towards openness by nurturing trust with external collaborators and by setting strategies together with other cultural organizations. Museums professionals' knowledge and know-how on social inclusion, accessibility and participatory approaches make a fertile land to motivate open approaches. Our workshops in the context of the AvoinGLAM initiative have provided inspiration to build this conversation and start thinking of future strategies.

Recently there have been many initiatives in which museums release digital collections with open licenses, people are able to adapt and edit the content that museums provide. In Finland the publication of metadata packages and APIs by museums (e.g. Finnish National Gallery 2013) that allow developers to create their own applications based on museum content is changing rules and practices. In these cases, people participate, and design and develop visualizations, services and apps utilizing a dynamic database. Once the data is released the possible uses or outcomes of this content are open to people's own skills and interpretations. The content and data could even be used against the goals and mission of the cultural organization. Openness gives space to the surprising and asks ethical questions concerning the future uses of our cultural heritage.

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